

## Class Taste

Chains clinked. The black wolf edged his way across the living room, a towering pile of pizza boxes cradled between two large paws. Forced to take small, mincing steps with a chain stretched between his ankles, silver toned manacles resting heavy above his hind paws. They acted as a constant reminder of his place. It was not as if they were intended to prevent him from running away, after all.

Don shuffled closer to the sofa set around the natural corner of the room, large enough to seat seven or eight prey animals with a squeeze and shuffle. A plush purple, the sofa was the choice of a female with fine taste, although he was yet to be invited up on the thick cushions to take the weight off his paws. No expense was spare on the sofa, but the wolf's manacles were silver toned only, falsifying their gleam. Don's ears drooped, blue eyes hazed over. The master and mistress of the household would never waste such an expense on him.

Squatting awkwardly to lower the pizza boxes on to the coffee table, he whimpered as a box slid askew. Panic fluttered in his chest but the Thompson's gazelle, one of the prey animals of the household, lying with her cloven hooves up in the lap of a male giraffe, paid him no mind.

Crowded on the sofa with five other mammalian prey animals, she was in her element, her brown eyes warm as the soft, living room light complimented her orange coat. Black triangles angled down her muzzle from eyes to nose with a white underside to her jaw and neck while the fur on the upper side of her muzzle shone deeper russet brown. Two striped horns rose from her skull, giving her an air of nobility. Predators didn't have horns, or at least none that Don had seen. The wolf grimaced, remembering the number of times she'd caught them on the curtains, peeking out as a younger gazelle. He'd taken the blame for her and beaten for his troubles.

The group laughed and chatted with one another as if he was not even in the room as he remained in his squat, awaiting further instructions. His thighs burned, a fierce ache, but he did not dare rise. His mistress' partner, the giraffe, was the first to reach for a slice of deliciousness with hoofed fingertips, greedy eyes fixed on the uppermost box. Don's stomach growled as pizza boxes flipped open, releasing their aroma into the air. He licked his lips. He'd never had pizza before.

The gazelle snapped her fingers.

"Stop eyeing it, predator," she said in a bored tone, one ear barely flicking in his direction. "This food is not yours and you know that well enough."

The wolf swallowed and cast his eyes down. All he wanted was a slice, just to see how it tasted. It had to be better than plain vegetables. Anything was better than vegetables for dinner, day after day. Old vegetables, more often than not.

"Is your predator too much for you to handle, dear Persephone?"

A grey squirrel giggled and cover her mouth politely with her paw as she chewed, holding a slice of pizza away from her pink dress. The morsel dripped with cheese and Don leaned forward, mouth watering.

Would one taste hurt?

“Of course not!” The gazelle shot back, eyes blazing.

Don gulped and froze, muscles trembling from holding his position. He couldn’t risk moving, not with Persephone engaged in conversation involving *him* right above his head. Though he could have not existed at all, for their conversation did not require him to speak.

The gazelle shook her head and slouched back on the sofa, shoulders hunched. Don supposed she was in her early twenties – he couldn’t remember how old she’d been on her last birthday – but it was not a matter that was important to him. He was always requested to wait on her at her parties, however: they were extravagant affairs. He never had anything to eat at them either. Her parents, the master and mistress of the household, could not have been around if she allowed her posture to slip. The giraffe, his long neck giving him greater sway, arched over to nuzzle her cheek, soft, grey lips playing over her neck.

“Isn’t he really your parents’ predator?” The squirrel pressed, licking grease from her fingers. “That means he doesn’t listen to you. At least mine are mine and they do as they’re told.” She pointed at Don, who shook. “He’s an untrained brute. Why is he not muzzled? All of *mine* are muzzled. As they well should be.”

The gazelle sat up straight and swung her hooves down to the floor. She brushed the giraffe aside, ignoring how he reached for her, and he hefted his arm over the back of the sofa instead, rolling his eyes. His fingers tapped a mindless tune that only he could hear.

“He listens to *me*,” Persephone snapped, back rigid. “Do you need me to show you just how obedient this brat of a wolf is?” Persephone jerked her horns towards Don, who tried to sink into the floor, wishing it would envelope him. “He shall do exactly as I say and be thankful for it too.”

The squirrel eyed her, a challenge in the set of her shoulders.

“Prove it.”

Don took a deep breath, scents thrumming potent in the air. Was she going to hurt him? What was happening? Why did she mind what the squirrel said so much? Why was it important? Determination clouded the natural scents, ringing through the clamour of multiple mammals seated around the room. He didn’t have to sift through the scents to pick out Persephone’s tone. A steely edge rang through like the clang of a knife on a metal saucepan – he’d heard that sound many a time from the resident zebra chef in a bad temper, feeling it fitting now – and he quailed into the ground. Pressing his muzzle into the carpet, he inhaled in short, sharp breaths, tail clamped down flat to his rump.

It was no good – no good at all! His heart pounded, sweat matting the fur under his arms as sickly dread roiled and twisted through his gut. He couldn’t save himself – the same as always! What he wanted didn’t matter; only what Persephone wanted would come to pass. And that would come with deafening certainty whether he agreed to it or not. He closed his eyes, forcing away the moisture behind him as his heart thudded painfully. Such was the life of a predator.

Sometimes it felt like it would be better if it all simply...stopped.

Standing over the prostate wolf, Persephone tapped a hoof.

“Predator.”

Don pricked his ears unwillingly.

“Lie down.”

The wolf’s ears slipped back to his skull and he obediently stretched out on his front, pressing forward until his thighs lay flat on the carpet. That was easy. A flicker of hope took hold of his heart and he counted his breaths, willing that to be the extent of her punishment. Perhaps it would be as simple as an obedience test, playing him like a trained dog. He exhaled slowly, calming his heart, eyes fixed on the gazelle’s hooves. He could deal with that.

“And up.”

He shuffled on to his knees, pushing up and away with his paws, but was shoved back down with a hoof between his shoulder blades. Holding his breath, Don wagged his tail, keeping it low and submissive. It could work. He could hope it would work. Though a prey animal would not recognise a lupine display of submission, perhaps it would show her that he meant no harm. He was no threat. The wolf trembled. He’d only wanted a piece of pizza.

“Paws stay on the floor, backside *down*,” she clarified with a wet snort. “Do not play dumb with me, predator. You know far better than that.”

Her fear was palpable on the air, garbed with a lick of doubt. Don whimpered and pushed his torso up while dropping his rump safely out of the line of fire. In the moment, he counted his blessings that his current household did not take out their frustrations on him in that way. His backside had taken more than enough abuse in his past for the wolf to staunchly bear through another whipping like that ever again. He thrust the images from his mind, stomach leaping into his throat.

His arms shook with the force it took to keep himself in place, knees bent and legs angled away to drop his tail as low as possible. He licked his lips, mouth dry. It seemed silly to have wanted the pizza after all that. What a waste of want that had been! His lip twitched, wanting to snarl, though he held himself in check. The gazelle paced around him and he battled down his fear, locking the hatch. What did she want with him? His eyes narrowed. He’d done nothing wrong. Nothing at all. So why was he the one being punished yet again?

Sliding the belt from her fashion sari – something inspired by true dress, or so she said – Persephone ran it between her fingers and doubled it back on itself. The woven fabric would be worthless for a true beating, a punishment to leave an impression, yet its implication made her friends balk, bursting into a chorus of mutters. The gazelle’s paw tightened on the tool. It gave her power.

The squirrel shook her head and reached out as if to stop her friend, jaw slack in a fashion that Don may have found amusing if not for his predicament. A soft mewl escaped her lips

like a breath of wind, too frail to make a difference. She was not the brightest of Persephone's friends, it had to be said. Don could have laughed if he'd had an ounce of humour, even dry humour, left in him. She wouldn't have had any idea of the trouble she was causing, what drama she stirred up through foolish words. *Bitch.*

"Persephone..."

The gazelle silenced her with a look that could have stayed an executioner's paw.

"Remain in position, predator."

Persephone towered over him. For a gazelle, that should have been impossible but Don shuddered away as her arm swung back, a shadow dropping over his exposed back as her weapon of choice cut across the soft overhead lighting. Anger licked at the pit of his stomach, ever hungry. She didn't even have the strength to take him on, one on one, without a substitute whip in her paw – a measly scrap of a leather belt! Prey needed tools to subdue predators as they held no natural weapons to compare.

That didn't mean the situation didn't blow donkey balls though, to be punished for something he hadn't even done.

*Fucking hell...*

The line of the wolf's jaw hardened. He tucked his tail down. Maybe she wouldn't hit his kidneys this time. Either way, he'd bloody well survive and come back fighting! She wouldn't have him! The bitch of a gazelle didn't know who she was messing with.

When the whistling blow came, it was lighter than expected, yet only half a second later the third and the fourth and the fifth snapped down. A flurry of strikes rained down on his back, the burn spreading and rising to a crescendo. His fur was thinner there with his summer coat coming through and he ground his teeth together, jaw throbbing with pain. But that was clean pain – he could focus on that.

The woven belt had been deceptive – it *stung*! Don closed his eyes, blocking out the glare of the world and the fascinated prey on the sofa. Distracting himself from the tedious curve of pain, he counted as high as he could remember and started again when he had reached that point, over and over again as pain mounted. Drool pooled in his muzzle, dripping down to the carpet in long ropes of spittle. He panted.

The squirrel giggled. He knew it was her. Only she had such a high pitched voice. The wolf broke as a vicious strike caught him atop the previous and howled, head whipping back. Sweat soaked his fur and the acrid stench made his nose wrinkle, distaste battling with fear. The squirrel cooed, murmuring something that he could not catch yet did not need to in order to understand. She took pleasure in his subjugation – it had been her motivation all along, such a ruse. She had never cared for his wellbeing, that Persephone would not beat him. Just like the rest of them. Breath tore through Don's lungs with difficulty and he stared at the same point on the carpet, a black speck of dirt embedded into the high class tawny. They were all the same, no one different to the rest of the herd.

Whereas the pain came to an end after a couple of minutes, maybe even three, the humiliation scarred Don's soul. The wolf dropped his torso and snuffled into the carpet, nose streaming and eyes watering. Putting her belt aside on the table, Persephone yanked him up by the leather collar and he yelped, counting his blessings that he no longer wore a muzzle to cage in his fangs. That hurt like the blazes when the collar was pulled and cut into his lips time and time again to score crimson lines.

She struck him flat across the muzzle with the palm of her paw and he couldn't stop himself – he hurt too much already. Instinct took over and a snarl ripped itself from his throat, lips curling up from teeth. It was weak, however, a dream of a memory from the time when his kind *had* voice, back when they had a snarl. Don's muzzle creased and he held the warning: *stay away*. Fuck it if he was punished! He clenched his paw. He was punished when it was not his fault so he may as well earn it.

Persephone smirked and petted him between the ears like she would do a pet, harder than necessary.

“Look at that muzzle, so fine.”

The gazelle crooned as she tilted the wolf's head from the left to the right, admiring him from all angles as his amber eyes remained stoic and impassive, snarl dying slowly. He willed his hackles down. If he fought back physically, he'd be locked up again! In the dark with no one for company. The wolf swallowed his snarl and dropped his eyes, loathing the need. He whined, fear still rumbling about his muzzle in the hint of a growl, eyes rimmed with an edge of white.

“This is why we chain you, sweet pea.” Her voice was sickly sweet as she traced a finger over his muzzle, ignoring the reappearing, deepening snarl. “So you *cannot* submit to baser instinct like your kind did long ago. You *cannot* have everything you want with no repercussions. Life is not like that anymore and it never will be again. This is a better time with prey binding you to submission. Wolves like pack behaviour, don't they?”

She giggled, eyes brighter.

“And you know where your position is in this pack. Right at the very bottom rung. Below it, even.”

She pushed him to the floor, disinterested with him now that she had made her point as clearly as only she could. Pressing his muzzle into the carpet, the pain dropped from Don's muzzle and he stared forlornly at the legs of the coffee table as Persephone's friends devoured the pizza, the gazelle in her rightful place in their midst. His lips once again covered his teeth as if to act as a gag, and the wolf curled into a ball, hugging his knees to his chest. He did not pretend that he wasn't crying, tears rolling down his muzzle and dripping off the end of his nose. It didn't matter. He whimpered, his back a mass of pain. No one would notice anyway.

The wolf flinched from their laughter and happy voices, sharing food as if it was the most normal thing in the world – well, perhaps for them. All he'd wanted was one, bite, just one, single bite. Had that been too much to ask? And he could have snapped and he could have snarled again, taking what he thought he deserved in the heat of the moment. Yet the rocking,

whimpering wolf beside the table made no such move, though the heat of anger seared painfully through the cavity of his chest. He was not sure there was anything left there anymore. And he did not snarl, no he would not snarl.

He did not snarl because he *was* a predator.

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“What’s got your tail so stiff?”

A wild dog, African, lay flat on his back on his narrow bed with a thin, threadbare mattress and jiggled his hind paw over the edge. His coat splashed through with orange, brown and white in no discernible pattern, shades blending seamlessly into one another as if he had been groomed with an artist’s brush, though his dark eyes followed Don’s restless pacing with hardened focus. His large ears, rounded at the tips, pricked to catch the smallest sound and he folded his paws together behind his head, ever watchful.

The wolf strode the length of the dormitory bedroom in the basement and threw a mental punch at the patch of damp streaking the corner of the ceiling where it met the wall – too high to reach. The master and mistress would never fix that. And the predators were the only ones ever to be found in the dorm, so why would they concern themselves with a trivial need? Don growled. No! They had parties and college and high flying jobs and *lives* to be getting on with. No need to worry about the needs of those they owned, living by their grace and generosity.

The canine snapped his fingers.

“Don!”

The wolf shook himself, amber eyes hazy.

“Sorry... Sorry, Rafa,” Don said, tongue thick in his mouth. “Didn’t mean to ignore.”

Studying him, Rafa did not say anything, the white tip of his tail flicking. Like the wolf, the canine wore nothing but his fur, which, for him, could have been pattern and cover enough. Sometimes Don found himself jealous of the colours in his fur and wished he could be garbed as such in finery.

The wolf paced the length of the room, turned on his heel and strode back again, stirring up dust in his passing. No one else had returned to the dorm, presumably occupied with other tasks within the household, and Don had nothing to occupy his mind beside endless walking within a room he could not escape until the morn. Even relieving himself was strictly controlled and, well, once a predator had entered the basement for the evening they were not expected to be seen in the public areas of the household. There was no way to reach their bathroom without disturbing the master and mistress.

And Persephone.

Don growled and paced some more, hind paws sore from being on them all day. He should have been resting yet his mind raced from one thought to the next, discarding each in turn as nothing of great interest, unable to settle.

“So what has got you acting like this?” Rafa probed. “Haven’t you got your book to read?”

Don shook his head.

“I lost it.”

Rafa widened his eyes, half sitting up on the bed.

“You lost it? But you read that book every night.”

“I know.” Don turned his shoulder to the dog. “But I lost it.”

Rafa shrugged. It was hard going to lose a possession even if it did not truly belong to them.

“I can’t stick this anymore,” Don snapped, slamming his palm into the wall. “All this...constant *doing*! Don’t we ever get to just forget all of this? Just maybe do nothing? Nothing at all?”

The wild dog rolled his eyes.

“We’re predators, Don, no forgetting about. How do we forget what our lives are?”

“I don’t know...” He interlocked his fingers behind his neck and paused, leaning forward to press his forehead to the cool, grey wall. “I only know that this...this life is killing me. It’s crazy. Stupid. Wrong. *Obscene*.”

“That’s a big word for you.”

“Oh, shut up.”

Don stood perfectly still as the wall warmed to touch, coolness swiftly evaporating. Other predators milled into the dorm in ones and twos until all were present, greeting one another with their usual chorus of barks and mews. He ignored them all, thrusting down the urge to turn and press his burning back up to the wall for a scrap of relieving cool. It would be too short lived to make any real difference, just like anything else.

That had to change. The wolf narrowed his eyes, vision enveloped by grey, grey, boring grey. And perhaps sooner rather than later, if he had anything to do with it. He snarled at nothing. He would have everything to do with it.

He became aware of someone standing behind him, tapping a paw on the stripped floor.

“What’s wrong with you?”

Don shrugged and pushed himself away from the wall, half-turning to glance over the curious younger wolf, a grey male that boasted startlingly blue eyes. It had been his eyes that

had secured his place in the household. With all the finery they could ever wish for, prey coveted beauty.

“I’m getting asking that a lot today.”

“Then why don’t you answer the question?”

The youngster challenged him, back straight down to his unyielding tail. At any other time, Don would have risen to the challenge, the open threat, in the only way he knew how, but found the youngster beneath him this night. Snorting hot air, he flipped his paw and joined Rafa on his bed. The poor excuse for a place to rest their heads was barely big enough to fit both of them. Rafa’s paws hung off the end when he lay on his back with his legs straight.

The wild dog yawned.

“Don got whipped.”

“Really?” The grey wolf’s face fell. “What did you do? Did you drop a plate? Scuff up the floor? It has to be something bad, you haven’t have a beating in...in...years!”

“Knock it off,” Don growled. “Who cares what happened? It’s no less than the rest of you lot would’ve gotten if you’d been in my place. She was trying to make a point and, well, I happened to be there. Sucks to be me, doesn’t it?”

“Sucks to be all of us,” Rafa chipped in.

“Yes...” The wolf said slowly. “It sucks to be all of us.”

Leaping up from the bed, though he had had little rest, the wolf took centre stage, encircled by bright-eyed predators. He spread his arms wide, encouraging them in closer and closer, close enough to hear him clearly. The wolf had never learned to throw his voice. He barked, tail set in challenge. Even Rafa lifted his head from the bed, acknowledging the call, and, albeit behind the curve, rose to his paws, tail wagging.

Pack mentality.

Turning in a tight circle, Don drew strength from the predators gathered around him, standing shoulder to shoulder with yearning, bright eyes. They hadn’t given up yet, even with their collars and chains, differing between bodies depending on their behaviour and the whims of the master and mistress. They were all there! There for him! His fellow predators would always have his back, not like any master or mistress he had ever had the misfortune to serve.

Not like Persephone. Not like *them*.

“This has to...stop and it stops now,” Don said, voice steadying as he spoke. “Why should we do what they want every day, day in and day out? Where’s the sense in it? What’s the point?”

A leopard snickered, tail curling sinuously back and forth, ever the picture of a restless feline. His black spots caught the eye, breaking up his outline.



“Because we’re predators,” he said so simply that Don almost felt dumb for posing the question initially. “What else are we meant to do? This,” he tugged his collar, “tells us where we belong in the world. It’s our place.” He pointed above their heads. “That is theirs.”

He jerked his head towards the door leading to the majority of the house to imply the prey overlords, raising one should in a shrug that he could not be bothered to complete. Don held up his paws, palms facing out, staving off the chorus of rising murmurs. Of course they would see it that way – they had never known anything different, had never challenged the norm. Neither had he, for that matter. But something deep inside, something primal, told the wolf that there was something better out there for them. For him. There was better than what they had.

The wolf shuffled, grit and tiny stones digging into the sensitive pads of his hind paws.

“Why?” He asked. “Why are we like this? Because we were subdued once? Why should we have to do what we don’t want to do every day? We don’t want to do chores and run errands. Prey are more than capable of doing that themselves, there’s no great difficulty in the menial. And they don’t tell us to do anything of great worth either. So why can’t they do it? Why does it fall to us? We were only overthrown *once*.”

Don stamped and growled until they fell silent, cowed by the alpha of their little group. The cats hadn’t taken well to his quiet leadership in the early days of the household but that had quickly changed. One would conform if they were only allowed! It was only in the best interests of the leopard and smaller serval to follow his guidance, after all. Don took a deep breath. He could do it. He could win them over. The canines and lupines were easier, more like him than the rest. Though they did not *think*, having no thoughts. His lips twisted. They would never think.

He twisted his fingers into the thick fur of his neck and yanked out hair with a half-stifled yelp, swallowing the turmoil. He didn’t have to educate them but he had to show them a better way, he had to help them and help himself. Don panted heavily, pink tongue lolling from his muzzle. He would *make* them think if they did not want to take the step themselves.

“We *can* take back what’s ours,” he insisted, stepping forward so they were forced to break the circle or have him crash into their line. “What do you think is holding us back? It’s certainly not these!”

Unbuckling the collar from around his neck, he held the brown, worn leather gingerly between a thumb and a forefinger. Don stared at it as anger coiled in the pit of his stomach and reared its ugly head, a snake’s tongue of fire flickering up to his heart. Bastards! Chaining him! Choking him with a collar! Not a single one of them deserved that treatment. They were better than that. They were *all* better than that!

The wolf snarled and hurled the collar across the dorm, watching it sail away as if from a great distance. It thudded into the wall and dropped lifelessly to the floor, buckle splayed open like a bitch’s legs. He couldn’t remember the last time he’d been around a she-wolf. If he was free, he could have a she-wolf. He could have a family. The wolf rocked his head from shoulder to shoulder, eyes hardening as his muzzle tipped back into a low, eerie howl that echoed around the basement. It was not as if he would be heard. The younger wolf joined

in with a broken howl, feeding off his energy, and the others lent their voices to strengthen his.

When Don stopped and looked about him at the faces and muzzles he loved so dearly, his only friends – the closest he had – could have been strangers with that dangerous gleam in their eyes. Leo, the inappropriately named leopard, licked his chops, fangs flashing. The wolf growled, his stronger paw clenched into a tight fist. Had he always had this side of himself locked up inside? This side that could rile up a pack to take on their oppressors? Don shifted his weight, imagining leaning forward into a fighting stance, ready to stalk his prey. Prey was there to be stalked, surely? It was in their make-up, who they quintessentially were. A howl tickled at his throat but he swallowed it down, just for the moment.

The wolf shook himself, lost in an imposter's body. It was unlike him, yet so inherently *right* in itself too. Yet a wicked little voice whispered in the back of his mind that he was only acting the part. The wolf paced back and forth, ignorant to the needs of his back. His anxiety riled them up more – he couldn't keep it under the hatch! They could never do it. He wasn't strong enough. They'd beat him again. The whip sailed through the air in his mind's eye, biting deep. Don growled and crouched, tail as rigid as a pine tree, hackles raised. They'd hurt his pack.

#### *His pack.*

Don hissed through his teeth and pressed his fingers to his temples, stifling a whimper. It didn't feel like he was in control of his own life anymore, if he'd ever been. He'd always known his place and been happy with that, at least. The wolf shook his head. Times were changing. Perhaps they were merely taking back what was rightfully theirs. It would be an unnerving notion at any time, regardless of the circumstances.

Rafa's eyes latched on to the collar, forlorn on the floor, and his paw rose to his own, muzzle wrinkling. His companions looked between one another, ears flicking as their eyes fell down, paws shifting constantly, each and every one of them on biting edge.

Don barked, voice echoing around the dingy basement.

"We can be predators again! We don't have to be servants forever – don't you see?" He barked, leaping up on to the end of one rickety bed. "What's stopping us? Our minds? We are stronger than them! They are more than us but they'll never see us coming! We are made for this! We are made to hunt down what we need while they are made to cower, to hide and flee from danger. We are the ones that embrace it – just for living!"

He paused, his eyes as hard as steel.

"We are made to survive."

"Oh, get off it." Rafa rolled his eyes; that was too far. "What do you think you can do, Don, yelp and chase your tail in a circle? We've all been doing what they want since we were born. That's not going to change now."

The wolf snarled and punched his fist into his opposite palm, ears dangerously flat to his skull. His muzzle contorted viciously and Rafa yelped, tail tucked down between his legs, the

urge to submit and show that he was not threat greater than the element of free will and knowing.

“Of course it’s not going to change if you stand there and say it won’t!” The wolf shook his head, legs trembling, yet he held firm. “We don’t think! We need to start thinking – that’s what they don’t want us to do and do you ever wonder why that is! Why they chain us? I’ll tell you why.”

He spread his hind paws further apart on the bed as the mattress creaked, smiling for the first time in months. Oh, they’d thought they’d hidden the secret years ago, yet they had dug it up from the grave and brushed off moist soil to reveal the truth. The predators knew.

“They are afraid of us.”

They murmured, muzzles bobbing in agreement; it was hardly a strange notion to consider when they were so often chained and muzzled for fear of their teeth and claws. Once, their little pack had even seen a lupine forced to walk on all fours like his feral ancestors. It was dehumanising. And all intentional, all very much intentional.

Rafa sighed and shrugged, eyes wistful as he looked at a point over Don’s shoulder.

“What do you think we should do?” He asked, the first of them to voice the question that was going around all of their heads.

Don didn’t know how he had come to be their accidental leader in striking back, standing tall on the bed with their trusting eyes looking up to him. The wolf set his shoulders back, hackles bristling. It was now or never if he wanted them with him. For there was one thing he knew with stinging certainty and that was that he could not do what he needed to alone. He would need every single member of his pack.

“We will take back what’s ours,” he said, lifting a clenched paw above his head. “First, this household will be ours. We will have all the food and comfort we have ever dreamed of. Beyond that, our right to be who we were born to be. Predators. We are *predators* and that is who we shall be. Not their servants.”

Don hesitated, a chuckle burbling forth and surprising him. Surely this was no time for mirth? The wolf curled and uncurled his raised paw, spreading his fingers wide. The fur on the back of his paw was scored through with burns from serving his masters.

“Apart from that...” He held up both paws. “Be whoever we want to be and do whatever we want to do. There’ll be nothing stopping us. Do what you want to do. It’s more than we’ve had so far and no one will be there to stop you. Not anymore.”

He spread his paws imploringly.

“Don’t you want that too?”

Leo scuffed a hind paw across the floor, the leopard swaying from side to side. He had never been one to require much persuasion, even for a feline.

“I do.”

The younger wolf growled, tail lifting as he looked up to his leader.

“I want it too.”

“Me too.”

One by one, each predator added their voice, growls and yowls rising into a cacophony of rebellious sound.

“How do we do it?”

Rafa asked the question that Don had half been dreading. How would they do it? What could they do? Stumbling from the bed, he faltered into their midst, half expecting the pack to turn away from him. How could he be a pack leader when prey was his true master still? Yet they lifted their paws to steady him as the wolf shivered under the weight of what he asked of them.

The lack of his collar gave him strength and Don imagined life without prey. It wasn't such a bad thought, fuelling his desire to free his friends with his cause. Equals. Was that so bad? Not for them, by any means. The prey on the other hand... Well, it would matter less what they wanted at the end of the day. He growled, muscles tensing. They'd had their turn.

But there was only one answer to Rafa's question. He flexed his toes, sinking into a half-crouch as he bared his teeth, weight shifting as if to spring at an imaginary foe. The felines hissed and gave him space, tails lashing, and even Rafa dipped his muzzle in submission. They all knew what the wolf was capable of and bore the scars to prove his dominance over them. If anyone could save them, it would be him.

“We *fight*,” he growled, anger ripping the words from his throat. “I don't know how yet, but I will soon. We'll come up with something, *anything*. But we will fight. We will use what our ancestors gave us, our wits and our instincts, to take back what was ours, too long ago.”

The wolf swallowed hard, tears stinging.

“And then...”

He rubbed the back of his paw across his muzzle, ears slanting back as Rafa squeezed his shoulder in a comforting grip. *I'm here.*

Don turned his muzzle to the ceiling as his comrades crowded around, sharing the warmth of their bodies, his pack nuzzling in close in support. In his mind's eye, he saw the starry heavens, stretching into infinity, as his pack hunted in the light of the moon. His imaginary muzzle tilted back to the galaxy above to let loose a howl that spoke of eons locked away. It had been too long since he had seen the outside world without a pane of glass in his way.

He leaned into Rafa with a light wag to his tail.

“And then... And then we shall be free.”

\*

Persephone's friends laughed on the sofa, eyes glued to the television. An antelope reached over to snag some popcorn out of the communal bowl, hooved fingertips scraping the glass as he clawed for it. Light from the television flickered across their entranced muzzles as they lost themselves in a cheesy film, something that would be swiftly forgotten.

Heavy footsteps sounded beyond the living room and the antelope tilted his horns inquisitively as a horde of predators marched into the room, muzzles lifted high. They lined up in front of the prey on the sofa, shoulder to shoulder, and blocked the television screen from view, eyes darting from fur to fur.

The antelope wrinkled his delicate muzzle. How strange!

"What are you doing in here?" Persephone's sort of boyfriend, the giraffe, demanded rudely. "Get back to the kitchen or wherever it is you're supposed to be here. Go *away*. We're too busy to keep you busy. Find something to do."

The leopard yawned, flashing startlingly white fangs that gleamed with spittle. Before, he would have been muzzled for such an indiscretion.

"Oh, we know what we're doing." His eyes glinted. "We're doing exactly what we want to do."

The giraffe jerked back but it was already too late. The predators tensed, the tails of the felines lashing. Everyone was doing what they wanted to do at long last. One of the younger wolves let loose a snarl that sent the prey quivering back into the plush cushions, eyes as wide as fawns seeing the world for the first time.

"Onwards!" Leo the leopard screamed, a feral yowl leaping unbidden from his throat.

With a shriek and a hiss, the predators – less than a dozen – struck with claws and teeth and the tools of their trade that had been locked away for decade upon decade upon decade. The motley pack descended on the screaming prey and the wiser sort bolted, streaking from the room in a broken blur. Fur tore from skin and one of the canines squealed as she was kicked in the ribs, though such a pitiful blow did nothing to stop the victim in the throes of bloodlust. The fox in the chicken coop laughed. So many of them! So close! All for the taking. Their taking.

Juan, a tiger, crouched low to the ground as he stalked one fur that had not had the good sense to at least leap out of the way. And now, her time was up.

Blubbering, the squirrel covered her muzzle with her paws and wailed into them as her life came to an end in a searing streak of crimson, pain fleeing before the darkness. Juan licked his muzzle clean, revelling in the metallic taste of blood. The squirrel crumpled to the floor, a broken toy tossed away.

*See you in the next one, squirrel-girl.*

Rafa yelped, snapping at the tail of the giraffe as he swore, barely evading. The wild dog's eyes followed his ropey tail as he fled, streaming behind him like a scraggly piece of string with the uncombed tuft on the end. It was a strange thing to notice in the moment but the giraffe running away made his legs tremble, whining with the instinctual desire to *chase*.

With a bloodied maw, the grey wolf howled, tipping his head back and Rafa joined him, barking and wagging his tail as if thrilled that their first strike had gone so well. In all truth, they had only killed two furs and, considering how many predators were gathered, it really was a pitiful number. They were rusty, out of practice, and had not yet learned how to kill. The hunt sent chords of joy through their hearts all the same.

Only Don was nowhere to be found, secluding himself away with other prey to hunt down no doubt, ever the lone wolf. It didn't matter – the predators were doing well enough without him. He'd arranged the strike and that was good enough for the pack. They could do without him as buried instinct flared to their fingertips. Why, they only had to call on it and it was there! It had always been there. And it gave them *power*.

The giraffe wheeled around the corner of a long hallway straight into Persephone, who clutched at his arms for balance, teetering on her tiny hooves. He clung to her, holding her so roughly that his hoofed fingers tore into her fine white sari.

“Richard!” She gasped, eyes wide. “What on earth is happening? I heard screams! Was that Celeste crying? What's –”

“Just run!” He gasped, one paw on the wall as he swayed on his long legs, desperately scraping air into sore lungs. “Gemini, she's already gone, they got her, she's gone, maybe Leopold too –”

“Gone? What do you mean *gone*? What's happening? Tell me what's going on!”

Richard shook his head, ears drooping but breath steadier. His heart thudded, the song in his head that of survival and survival alone. He had to survive. Persephone had to survive. He pressed his cheek to the gazelle's, forcing out the words through dry-mouthed wheezes.

“The predators, they've gone wild, every one of them!” He swallowed as her body stiffened against him. “We've got to get out of here, run, escape, flee – anything! Out! Out!”

He drew his head back enough to look her levelly in the eye, a paw wrapped around each of her tiny biceps. They would eat her up in one bite.

“Run, Persephone. *Run*.”

Grabbing her paw, Richard hauled the gazelle after him and she burst into a mindless run, legs working to keep up with his longer ones. Her head reeled with the thought that the predators – her predators! – were on the loose in the house, rampaging as they had in olden days, destroying everything she held close and dear. Gemini was dead? They'd killed? Predators had not done that in years! Persephone whimpered, tugging on the giraffe's paw as he skidded around the corner to the entrance hall, front door within reach.

The wolf moved in a grey blur, launching himself through the air with a feral snarl and crazed eyes. Persephone watched him fly over her as if in slow motion, adrenaline tingling through her veins, spittle streaming from his jaws in long ropes as they parted wider and wider and wider. Only to close around her boyfriend's throat.

Putting the pressure on below the giraffe's jaw, the grey wolf bore him to the ground, pouring his prey's life essence on to the expensive floorboards. His breath came harshly and his long, black tongue lolled from his muzzle as he scrabbled, struggles growing weaker with every passing second. Persephone stared in horror, legs trembling so badly that her knees clacked together. Looking her in the eye as the light faded from his, Richmond mouthed one word: *run*.

So run she did. She couldn't breathe but she ran. And ran. Dodging other predators roaming her home without rhyme or reason, she skirted the crux of chaos and, heart pounding, sought solace in the kitchen. Hide, hide, hide, she chanted to herself, lips moving though she did not know if any words came out. Could she lock herself in the walk in freezer until her parents came home? Would the predators find her there? Would the cold be too much?

Richmond's dead eyes glimmered. She'd left the giraffe lying in a pool of his own...no. *No*. Something twisted viciously in her chest and the gazelle clapped a paw over her muzzle as her stomach roiled, willing herself to not vomit. Pain shot through her and she didn't know if she hurt from fleeing or from something more, something worse. She forced herself to take one shaky step after the other towards the kitchen door, wavering in her line of sight as if she had consumed too much alcohol. The room spun. Her cheeks grew wet.

*Richmond...*

Closing her eyes against his image, she stumbled into the kitchen and put her back to the heavy door, only to come upon the most unexpected sight of her evening.

Don stood in the kitchen over a beautiful, three tier cake, an apron hooked over his head and tied at the back. A pure white, it was dotted with what looked to be paw-made pink roses of the most delicate spun sugar. The wolf jerked his head up as she entered, eyes narrowed into slits.

"What... What are you doing?" She stuttered.

The wolf sighed and straightened, stretching out the kinks in his back by raising his arms over his head.

"What does it look like I'm doing? I'm icing a cake."

The gazelle looked between the wolf and the cake as if he had gone mad. Maybe she had lost her mind after Richmond's death. It would make sense. Don's lips pressed into a hard line.

"Don't get excited." He rolled his eyes, picking up a tube of blue icing. "It's not for you."

"Then *who* in heaven and earth is it for?"

Even with the household in chaos and half her friends dead, the demand spilled from her lips. And, once it was said, she wished she could snatch it back. Yet she had to know, she had to know why he had caused so much carnage only to bake a cake, for surely the stubborn lupine was the instigator above all others. Why would he even want to bake a cake? The wolf never had cake. Persephone's head spun.

"It's for me," he said. "Is that so hard to believe?"

She flinched from his callous, snide undertone, anger flicking back to life in the cauldron of her stomach. A cake? A *cake*? The gazelle gave a series of rapid grunts and Don started, eyes wide at the sudden sound. The icing tube shuddered in his paws.

"Do you have any *idea* what you've done?" She snarled, flinging her arms wide. "Didn't you see what your kind has done out there?"

Don blinked and tilted his head to the side.

"Doing what they want to do," he said, too simply. "Isn't that what they are doing?"

Persephone laughed, though there was no humour in her tone.

"Oh, of course they are, if maiming and killing is what your *friends* like to do. Though I shouldn't be surprised," she continued, leaning back against the wall, arms crossed over her skinny chest. "It's what you are. Predators. That's all that predators like. And what can we do to stop you?"

She was suddenly as small and frail as her young years and Don replaced the tube of icing on the counter, ears folded. He fiddled with the beige apron, but could not bring himself to remove it. The apron was what he wanted.

What the others wanted was not what he wanted. He hadn't considered that. The wolf gulped. He should have thought of that.

"Blood and guts everywhere." The gazelle slid down the wall to sit on the floor, legs tucked close to her chest. "I'm surprised to not see blood staining your fur too, wolf. That's all your kind is good for, with those teeth. You like to rip into flesh, do you not?"

"No..." Don shook his head, a low whine building. "I don't like it. I don't like it, ma... Persephone."

The gazelle looked up, mascara streaking her muzzle.

"You fool," she said quietly. "You absolute and utter fool. We were right in what we did. We were right in keeping you chained if this is how you behave, all for the sake of doing what you want to do. You don't deserve to live."

She shook her head, dipping her muzzle to her knees, and hugged her legs to her chest. Tears streamed down her cheeks, dripping on to her legs, dirtied and bloodied with fluid that was not hers. He could see her cry. It did not matter anymore. She didn't have to be strong when he had already proven his absolute weakness.



Don pressed his paws over his eyes.

“I just wanted to make a cake,” he said in a very small voice. “It’s all I’ve ever wanted to do and you and your family stopped me. I wanted to bake cakes. I wanted to decorate. Master... No, the zebra, Bariki, said that was his job. Not mine.”

“Yeah?” Persephone forced out through her sobs. “That’s your problem, mutt. Now you’ve made it everyone else’s problem too. Fucking deal with it. Your mess. You clean it up.”

Don stood dumbfounded as his paws began to shake. Outside the door, a wolf howled, and Don jumped, hackles lifting. His muzzles wrinkled as he scented blood, viciously primal. Instinct was more powerful than a fur’s simple desire.

And yet he clung on to it with the tenacity of a dying man, hanging off the thread of want and life until the very point at which it snapped.

“I wanted to bake a cake.”

The gazelle snapped, staggering to her feet with fists flying in all directions. Don didn’t even flinch, instead holding her at arm’s length as he settled into himself, resolving hardening. Let the bitch scream. He would bake his cake. He growled, ears pinned flat, as the little gazelle fell limp in his paws. She couldn’t even support her own weight.

“Imbecile.” Persephone hissed, head lolling to the side and hooves dangling as he lifted her. “Do you see what trouble you’ve caused? Do you not know what you’ve done?”

The wolf swept his gaze around the kitchen, roaming over powdery flour to a cup tipped sideways next to the sink. The contents had spilled out of the glass and water trickled down the cupboards below the kitchen units. Slowly, the wolf smiled, his grin growing wider and wider until it stretched from ear to ear. The gazelle’s eyes bulged out of their sockets and she squirmed as he lifted her higher, bringing her muzzle up to the same level as his. Don smirked.

“I see furs doing what they want to do,” he told her. “And that is all they should be doing, whatever names you call me.”

Simplicity rang through his words and, though Persephone scoffed, she had no retort. Don giggled, a mischievous little sound that came unnaturally to his lips, and she screamed in his face, throwing her body from side to side in a futile attempt to free herself. But, as she had locked the wolf in chains, he now had her in his grasp. Power surged through him, tingling down to the tips of his fingers.

“If I want to bake my cake, they can also do what they want.”

He glanced back over his shoulder as something heavy thudded into the opposite side of the kitchen door, handle juddering threateningly. A body? One of many, he supposed. But bodies weren’t so bad if they were a means to an end. It was the way of life, at least for a predator, to have death involved. Could he complain of the natural way? Don smiled.

“You asked what I see... Well, I see a revolution. Don’t you?”

Dropping Persephone, Don stalked from the kitchen with his head held high and his shoulders set back. Joining his pack, he hurled himself into the fray and drove them onwards to sweet victory.

And so the great predator rebellion began, the sparks set off in one household that would not have made a difference in the grand scheme of things if fate had called a different hand. From the decimation of the prey in Persephone’s household, the seed was planted and others around the known world took back what was theirs, bloodying the soil with tooth and claw. Persephone was kept safe by a strong-armed black wolf with fire in his eyes, fuelled by the roar of rebellion for what he believed was a better world.

Predators could have taken the same path and enslaved every prey animal that they did not add to the pile of bodies in their wake. The outcome could have been very different to what it was. Predators could have reigned supreme with an iron fist – with due right, for had they not been treated unjustly by their overlords, after all? It was a good thing they had a wolf with a fair on his shoulders as their leader, bringing equality to a world that had forgotten that some furs did not want to suffer or cause suffering.

No. Some furs just wanted to bake a cake.

And that was all they wanted to do.